

Hampi Virupaksha Temple

The site of the city of Vijayanagar on the bank of the river Tungabhadra in eastern Karnataka is now called Hampi. Hampi is in ruins and the UNESCO has declared it a heritage site.

Aravidu Dynasty

Rama Raya was killed on the battlefield and his brother Tirumaladeva Raya managed to escape along with the king Sadasiva Raya. Tirumaladeva Raya moved to Chandragiri carrying all the treasures and wealth that could be salvaged. There he began the rule of Aravidu dynasty.

The Aravidu dynasty built a new capital at Penukonda and kept the empire intact for a time. Internal dissensions and the intrigues of the sultans of Bijapur and Golconda, however, led to the final collapse of the empire about 1646.

Vijayanagar Administration

State

Kingship was hereditary, based on the principle of primo geniture. But in some instances, the reigning rulers, in order to ensure peaceful succession, nominated their successors. There were also instances of usurpation. Saluva Narasimha usurped the throne and it led to the replacement of Sangama dynasty with Saluva dynasty. The practice of appointing a regent to look after the administration, when a minor succeeded the throne, was also prevalent.

Structure of Governance

The empire was divided into different *mandalams* (provinces), *nadus* (districts), *sthalas* (taluks) and finally into *gramas* (villages). Each province was administered by a governor called Mandalesvara. The lowest unit of the administration was the village. Each village had a grama sabha. Gauda, village headman, looked after the affairs of the village.

The army consisted of the infantry, cavalry and elephant corps. The army was modernised and Vijayanagar army began using firearms. The combination of firearm and cavalry made them one of the most feared armies in India.

Economic Condition

The Vijayanagar Empire was one of the richest states then known to the world. Several foreign travellers, who visited the empire during the fifteenth and the sixteenth centuries, left behind glowing accounts of its splendour and wealth.The emperors issued a large number of gold coins called Varahas.



Gold Coins of Vijayanagar Empire

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